CDL Doubles and Triples Test Questions and Answers

30 practice questions with answers and explanations, grouped by topic

Written from the Commercial Driver's License Manual (Version 07/20/2026 (form DMV 60A), AAMVA, Virginia DMV edition). Each answer names the manual section it comes from.

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How to use this PDF: answer the questions in Part 1 first, then check yourself with the answer key in Part 2.

Passing score on each CDL knowledge test: at least 80% correct (49 CFR 383.135).

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Part 1: Questions

Pulling double and triple trailers (7 questions)

1. Why are doubles and triples more likely to turn over than other combination vehicles?

- **A.** Because of the crack-the-whip effect
- **B.** Because of the brake fade effect
- **C.** Because of the air lag effect
- **D.** Because of the bobtail effect

2. A curve speed that is safe for a single trailer combination vehicle may be:

- **A.** Always safe for a set of doubles or triples
- **B.** Too slow for a set of doubles or triples
- **C.** Too fast for a set of doubles or triples
- **D.** Safe for doubles or triples only when empty

3. In bad weather, why is there a greater chance of skids and loss of traction with double and triple bottoms?

- **A.** The rear trailers have no brakes on their axles
- **B.** Their tires are narrower than other truck tires
- **C.** They have more length and more dead axles to pull
- **D.** They have fewer axles than other combination vehicles

4. Converter dollies built on or after which date are required to have antilock brakes?

- **A.** January 1, 1990
- **B.** July 1, 1995
- **C.** March 1, 2008
- **D.** March 1, 1998

5. **Besides being longer, why do doubles and triples need more space than other commercial vehicles?**
   - **A.** They must always travel in the right lane
   - **B.** They cannot be turned or stopped suddenly
   - **C.** They need room for the dolly to swing out
   - **D.** They have to stop at every weigh station

6. **Why should you look far ahead when driving doubles or triples?**
   - **A.** So you can brake hard at the last moment
   - **B.** So you can pass slower traffic more quickly
   - **C.** So you can spot weigh stations before others
   - **D.** So you can slow down or change lanes gradually

7. **When parking doubles or triples, what kind of spot should you avoid getting into?**
   - **A.** A spot you cannot pull straight through
   - **B.** A spot that is wider than your rig
   - **C.** A spot on firm and level pavement
   - **D.** A spot close to the exit of the lot

Coupling and uncoupling (11 questions)

8. **When uncoupling the rear trailer, what is the last step before slowly pulling the dolly out from under the rear semitrailer?**
   - **A.** Release the pintle hook on the first trailer
   - **B.** Disconnect the safety chains on the dolly
   - **C.** Raise the landing gear of the rear trailer
   - **D.** Release the converter dolly fifth wheel latch

9. **When you wheel the converter dolly into place in front of the second trailer, what should it be lined up with?**
   - **A.** The landing gear of the second trailer
   - **B.** The glad hands of the second trailer
   - **C.** The kingpin of the second trailer
   - **D.** The rear axle of the first trailer

10. **Before positioning a converter dolly that does not have spring brakes, how do you release the dolly brakes?**
    - **A.** Open the dolly air tank petcock
    - **B.** Pull out the trailer air supply knob
    - **C.** Close the shut-offs on the first trailer
    - **D.** Release the pintle hook on the trailer

11. **For the safest handling on the road, where should the more heavily loaded semitrailer go in a set of doubles?**
    - **A.** In the rear position, behind the dolly
    - **B.** In first position, right behind the tractor
    - **C.** In either position if the dolly has ABS
    - **D.** In the rear position on slippery roads

12. **After backing the converter dolly under the rear trailer, why do you raise the landing gear slightly off the ground?**
    - **A.** To level the trailer for the brake test
    - **B.** To let air reach the trailer brakes
    - **C.** To unlock the dolly fifth wheel latch
    - **D.** To prevent damage if the trailer moves

13. **For a combination whose coupling method is not covered in the manual, how should you learn to couple and uncouple it?**
    - **A.** By using the triples method for every rig
    - **B.** By using the tractor-semitrailer method
    - **C.** By asking any driver who has pulled one
    - **D.** From the manufacturer and/or owner specifications

14. **How do you test the coupling after backing the converter dolly under the second semitrailer?**
    - **A.** Push the trailer air supply knob in and out
    - **B.** Pull against the pin of the second semitrailer
    - **C.** Back firmly against the first semitrailer
    - **D.** Lift the dolly tongue by hand to see if it moves

15. **When uncoupling a triple-trailer rig, which trailer do you uncouple first?**
    - **A.** The first trailer
    - **B.** The second trailer
    - **C.** The third trailer
    - **D.** The heaviest trailer

16. **Once the dolly is out from under the rear trailer, what is the first step in uncoupling the converter dolly?**
    - **A.** Release the pintle hook
    - **B.** Lower the dolly landing gear
    - **C.** Slowly pull clear of the dolly
    - **D.** Disconnect the safety chains

17. **When uncoupling the rear trailer, how far should you lower the second semitrailer's landing gear?**
    - **A.** Enough to remove some weight from the dolly
    - **B.** Just until it touches, with no weight on it
    - **C.** Until the trailer lifts fully off the dolly
    - **D.** Not at all until the dolly is pulled out

18. **Where should you park the rig before uncoupling the rear trailer of a set of doubles?**
    - **A.** On a slight downgrade so the dolly rolls free
    - **B.** At an angle so the dolly can come out sideways
    - **C.** In a straight line on firm, level ground
    - **D.** On soft ground so the landing gear can sink in

Inspecting doubles and triples (7 questions)

19. When inspecting the air lines to the trailer, how should they be secured?

- **A.** With enough slack for turns
- **B.** Pulled tight so they cannot move
- **C.** Tied to the landing gear crank
- **D.** Wrapped around the safety chains

20. The extra coupling and trailer checks for doubles and triples are added to which step of the Section 2 inspection?

- **A.** Step 2
- **B.** Step 5
- **C.** Step 6
- **D.** Step 7

21. Why should you check that the fifth wheel is not too far forward?

- **A.** So the air lines can reach the glad hands without stretching
- **B.** So the frame and cab do not hit the landing gear or trailer in turns
- **C.** So the trailer does not sit too high on the fifth wheel
- **D.** So the locking jaws can reach the head of the kingpin

22. When checking the lower fifth wheel, where should the locking jaws be closed?

- **A.** Around the head of the kingpin, not the shank
- **B.** Around the glide plate on the trailer frame
- **C.** Around the shank of the kingpin, not the head
- **D.** Around the pintle-eye of the converter dolly

23. If the landing gear is power operated, what should you check for during the inspection?

- **A.** The crank handle has been removed
- **B.** The legs rest lightly on the ground
- **C.** No air or hydraulic leaks
- **D.** The motor stays on while driving

24. Which inspection procedure should you use to inspect a double or triple combination vehicle?

- **A.** The seven-step procedure described in Section 2
- **B.** A five-step procedure used only for trailers
- **C.** A ten-step procedure done only at a shop
- **D.** A two-step check of the tractor and dolly

25. When inspecting a sliding fifth wheel, what should you confirm about the locking pins?

- **A.** At least half of them are engaged
- **B.** They are removed before driving
- **C.** They are greased and left unlocked
- **D.** All are present and locked in place

Doubles and triples air brake check (5 questions)

26. Why must air reach all the way to the back of a double or triple rig?

- **A.** So the trailer lights get power
- **B.** So the landing gear can be raised
- **C.** So the dolly ABS lamp will light
- **D.** So all the brakes will work

27. The trailer air supply control is also called the:

- **A.** Trailer hand valve
- **B.** Tractor protection valve control
- **C.** Service line shut-off
- **D.** Converter dolly petcock

28. In normal operation, the foot brake pedal applies air to which brakes?

- **A.** Only the trailer emergency brakes
- **B.** Only the tractor steering axle brakes
- **C.** The service brakes at all wheels
- **D.** Only the converter dolly brakes

29. If the tractor protection valve does not work properly and a trailer brake leak drains all the air from the tractor, what could happen?

- **A.** The emergency brakes could come on, with possible loss of control
- **B.** The trailer lights could stop working until the leak is fixed
- **C.** The engine could shut off to save the remaining air
- **D.** The service brakes would work but the parking brake would not

30. In the tractor protection valve test, the trailer air supply control should pop out when air pressure falls into the manufacturer's range, which is usually:

- **A.** 5 to 15 psi
- **B.** 60 to 75 psi
- **C.** 90 to 100 psi
- **D.** 20 to 45 psi

Part 2: Answer key

Each answer has a short explanation in our own words and the CDL manual section it comes from. Reread that section for every question you missed.

Pulling double and triple trailers

1. **A. Because of the crack-the-whip effect**
   The manual names the crack-the-whip effect as the reason these rigs tip over more readily, which is why gentle steering matters so much.
   Manual section 7.1.2 Beware of the Crack-the-whip Effect

2. **C. Too fast for a set of doubles or triples**
   Doubles and triples need a lower speed on curves than a straight truck or single trailer rig, so a speed that works for those can still be too fast.
   Manual section 7.1.1 Prevent Trailer from Rolling Over

3. **C. They have more length and more dead axles to pull**
   The drive axles have to pull a longer rig with more unpowered axles behind them, so slippery roads and mountain driving call for extra care.
   Manual section 7.1.6 Adverse Conditions

4. **D. March 1, 1998**
   The manual sets March 1, 1998 as the build date from which converter dollies must come with antilock brakes.
   Manual section 7.1.8 Antilock Braking Systems on Converter Dollies

5. **B. They cannot be turned or stopped suddenly**
   Because these rigs cannot make sudden turns or stops, you leave more following distance and wait for bigger gaps in traffic.
   Manual section 7.1.5 Manage Space

6. **D. So you can slow down or change lanes gradually**
   These rigs must be driven very smoothly to avoid a rollover or jackknife, and seeing trouble early gives you time to make gradual changes.
   Manual section 7.1.4 Look Far Ahead

7. **A. A spot you cannot pull straight through**
   Getting out of a tight spot with more than one trailer can be long and hard, so pick a place you can drive straight out of.
   Manual section 7.1.7 Parking the Vehicle

Coupling and uncoupling

8. **D. Release the converter dolly fifth wheel latch**
   Once the dolly's fifth wheel latch is released, the tractor, first trailer and dolly are eased forward together so the dolly comes out from under the rear trailer.
   Manual section 7.2.2 Uncoupling Twin Trailers

9. **C. The kingpin of the second trailer**
   The dolly has to sit in line with the second trailer's kingpin so it can then be backed under that trailer.
   Manual section 7.2.1 Coupling Twin Trailers

10. **A. Open the dolly air tank petcock**
    Letting the air out through the dolly tank petcock frees its brakes so it can be moved; a dolly with spring brakes uses its parking brake control instead.
    Manual section 7.2.1 Coupling Twin Trailers

11. **B. In first position, right behind the tractor**
    Putting the heavier trailer up front and the lighter one at the back gives the safest handling.
    Manual section 7.2.1 Coupling Twin Trailers

12. **D. To prevent damage if the trailer moves**
    Lifting the landing gear a little keeps it from being damaged should the trailer shift before the coupling is finished.
    Manual section 7.2.1 Coupling Twin Trailers

13. **D. From the manufacturer and/or owner specifications**
    There are too many truck-trailer and tractor-trailer types for one manual, so you follow what the maker or owner of your vehicle specifies.
    Manual section 7.2.4 Coupling and Uncoupling Other Combinations

14. **B. Pull against the pin of the second semitrailer**
    Pulling forward against the second trailer's kingpin shows whether the dolly's fifth wheel has really locked onto it.
    Manual section 7.2.1 Coupling Twin Trailers

15. **C. The third trailer**
    You work from the back: the third trailer comes off first, and the rest of the rig is then uncoupled like a set of doubles.
    Manual section 7.2.3 Coupling and Uncoupling Triple Trailers

16. **B. Lower the dolly landing gear**
    The dolly's own landing gear goes down first, before the safety chains are undone and the pintle hook is released.
    Manual section 7.2.2 Uncoupling Twin Trailers

17. **A. Enough to remove some weight from the dolly**
    The landing gear is lowered until it takes some of the load off the dolly, not just until it touches the ground.
    Manual section 7.2.2 Uncoupling Twin Trailers

18. **C. In a straight line on firm, level ground**
    Having the rig straight and on solid, level ground keeps the trailers and dolly steady while you separate them.
    Manual section 7.2.2 Uncoupling Twin Trailers

Inspecting doubles and triples

19. **A. With enough slack for turns**
    The air lines must be fastened in place but still have enough extra length to allow for turns.
    Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

20. **B. Step 5**
    These extra checks are added to the walk-around part of the inspection, which is Step 5 in Section 2.
    Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

21. **B. So the frame and cab do not hit the landing gear or trailer in turns**
    If the fifth wheel sits too far forward, parts of the tractor can strike the trailer or its landing gear when the rig turns.
    Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

22. **C. Around the shank of the kingpin, not the head**
    The jaws must close on the kingpin's shank; jaws closed on the head of the kingpin do not pass the check.
    Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

23. **C. No air or hydraulic leaks**
For landing gear that is power operated, the inspection includes making sure nothing is leaking air or hydraulic fluid.
Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

24. **A. The seven-step procedure described in Section 2**
Doubles and triples are inspected with the same seven-step method as other vehicles, plus extra items for the added trailers and couplings.
Manual section 7.3 Inspecting Doubles and Triples

25. **D. All are present and locked in place**
Every locking pin on a sliding fifth wheel has to be there and engaged, not just some of them.
Manual section 7.3.1 Additional Checks

Doubles and triples air brake check

26. **D. So all the brakes will work**
Air has to flow through every trailer and dolly to the last trailer, or some of the brakes will not work.
Manual section 7.4.1 Additional Air Brake Checks

27. **B. Tractor protection valve control**
The manual uses both names for the same control, and it may also be called the trailer emergency valve.
Manual section 7.4.1 Additional Air Brake Checks

28. **C. The service brakes at all wheels**
The hand valve is used for testing the trailer brakes, but in everyday driving the foot pedal sends air to the service brakes on every wheel.
Manual section 7.4.1 Additional Air Brake Checks

29. **A. The emergency brakes could come on, with possible loss of control**
A faulty tractor protection valve lets a trailer leak empty the tractor's air too, and losing that air sets the emergency brakes, which can cost you control.
Manual section 7.4.1 Additional Air Brake Checks

30. **D. 20 to 45 psi**
The control should move to the emergency position once pressure drops into the maker's range, normally somewhere from 20 to 45 psi.
Manual section 7.4.1 Additional Air Brake Checks

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